

CHAPTER 7 — Private Number

The hatchback entered the motorway in the wrong direction.

Zoe noticed immediately.

“The address is west.”

“I know.”

“You’re going east.”

“Yes.”

“Why?”

“Because they know the address is west.”

Elias moved into the middle lane and allowed two faster cars to pass before checking the service-area slip road behind them.

No vehicle emerged.

That meant little.

Cain’s people had phones, backup and the registration of the hatchback. Punctured tyres bought minutes. Sometimes minutes were the difference between escape and a better-organised pursuit.

Zoe twisted to look through the rear window.

“Sit properly.”

“I can see more.”

“You can also break your neck if I brake.”

She turned forward but remained leaning between the seats.

The navigation app recalculated.

Make a U-turn where possible.

Elias silenced the voice.

The blue route continued trying to drag them back towards Mac's destination.

He left it visible long enough for Zoe to see that he was deliberately ignoring it.

"Are we still going to the grandmother?" she asked.

"That depends."

"On what?"

"What you tell me."

Her arms tightened around the backpack.

Elias saw the movement in the mirror.

He did not ask about it.

They passed the first junction.

Elias remained on the motorway.

At the second, he left without signalling until the final safe moment, travelled around the roundabout and re-entered the motorway westbound using a different slip road.

Zoe watched each turn.

"That only changed the direction."

"It also showed whether anyone committed to the first route."

"Did they?"

"No."

"You don't know."

"No."

"You say that a lot."

"It prevents confidence becoming evidence."

She sat back.

The service area had disappeared.

Open road replaced it.

Heat shimmered above the tarmac. The old hatchback's windows remained open, pulling wind through the cabin and making conversation uneven.

For several miles, neither spoke.

Elias checked mirrors, overpasses, entry ramps and the vehicles that stayed with them through more than one junction. A white van followed for six miles, then exited. A motorcycle held position two cars back before overtaking and disappearing ahead.

No confirmed pursuit.

Not clean.

Only unconfirmed.

Zoe looked at the cut across his knuckle.

"You said the blood wasn't yours."

"Mostly."

"Whose was it?"

"A man who objected to me walking behind the building."

"You fought him."

"He grabbed my jacket."

"That isn't an answer."

"No."

“What happened?”

“He let go.”

She looked at the dust on his sleeve.

“He didn’t choose to.”

Elias did not respond.

Zoe watched the road.

“How did you disable the cars?”

“I damaged one tyre on each vehicle positioned for pursuit.”

“Two tyres collapsed on the saloon.”

“One problem can damage a second if the driver moves badly.”

“How?”

“With something from my tool kit.”

“What thing?”

“You don’t need the method.”

“You keep deciding what I need.”

“Yes.”

“At least you admit it.”

“The method buys a few minutes and leaves whoever uses it beside angry people and moving vehicles. It is not a lesson.”

“So they can repair them.”

“Yes.”

“Then they’ll follow.”

“Yes.”

"How long?"

"Depends on whether they carry spares, repair foam, another vehicle or enough authority to take one from someone else."

Zoe looked through the rear window again.

"That could be now."

"Yes."

Elias left the motorway at the next exit.

The road curved through an industrial estate of wholesale warehouses, vehicle depots and fenced compounds. He drove beneath a railway bridge, used two parallel streets and stopped briefly at a red light where three directions remained available.

No vehicle repeated.

He turned north, crossed a canal and rejoined a different trunk road.

Zoe followed every movement.

"You do this automatically."

"Drive?"

"Lose people."

Elias's hands remained steady on the wheel.

"I used to dislike company."

"That isn't an answer."

"No."

The phone vibrated inside its dashboard mount.

PRIVATE NUMBER

No X-Files ringtone.

Mac's assigned contact had one.

This caller did not.

Elias rejected the call.

It returned before the screen went dark.

He rejected it again.

The third call arrived immediately.

Zoe watched his thumb remain above the screen.

"Don't answer."

"I wasn't planning to."

The phone rang until the network ended the call.

Silence returned.

A message appeared.

THE REAPER SHOULD HAVE STAYED DEAD.

Elias read the words.

The road remained visible.

The car remained beneath his hands.

The present did not change.

His body did.

A place beneath his ribs tightened where old pain had no claim.

The motorway noise flattened into the distant metallic roar of another building.

Concrete under his knees.

A loading-bay door suspended halfway open.

His trainee's jacket hanging from a nail because Elias had not been able to throw it away.

A voice behind him saying the name as though it belonged to something no longer human.

Reaper.

The word had begun as a description used by frightened men who survived long enough to exaggerate.

Later, other men used it before meetings, on telephones and inside warnings.

Eventually Elias used it himself because names were tools and that one opened doors before he reached them.

Then his trainee died.

Afterwards, the name became the only part of Elias anyone remembered.

He had spent years making it belong to someone else.

The message put it back in his car.

Zoe leaned forward.

"What's a Reaper?"

Elias removed the phone from the mount and locked the screen.

"A name that belongs to someone else."

"They sent it to you."

"People send messages to ghosts every day."

"The man at the services knew."

"He recognised a story."

"He looked afraid."

“Stories are designed to produce that.”

Zoe watched his face in the mirror.

The driver who had argued over mayonnaise was still there.

So was the man from the restaurant.

Neither cancelled the other.

“Are you dangerous?” she asked.

“Yes.”

The answer arrived before Elias could make it easier.

Zoe sat back.

Not recoiling.

Creating enough distance to understand.

“To me?”

“No.”

“How do I know?”

“You don’t.”

The answer offered no reassurance. Only honesty.

Elias placed the phone inside the cup holder rather than returning it to the mount.

The message remained locked away.

“Why did you help me?” Zoe asked.

“Because Cain’s people were outside.”

“You could have left.”

“Yes.”

"They offered you that."

"Yes."

"You didn't."

"No."

"Why?"

Elias looked at the road.

Answers based on instinct sounded false when spoken aloud.

Because she was thirteen.

Because she had checked the child lock before entering the car.

Because Mac had called her family while giving Elias no family contact.

Because the woman at Arrivals had handed Zoe across a bureaucratic line and vanished.

Because Cain's people expected every ordinary person to prefer safety over interference.

Because his trainee had once stood where he was told not to stand and made a choice Elias had spent years trying to reduce to a mistake.

He gave Zoe the part that belonged to her.

"Because Cain does not get to take another child if I can stop him."

"You called me a child."

"You are one."

"That doesn't mean I'm helpless."

"No."

"Or stupid."

"No."

"You thought both at the airport."

"I thought you were difficult."

"I am."

"Yes."

The answer almost became humour.

It did not fully reach either of them.

Zoe looked towards the side window.

"You think I'm clever now?"

"I think you understood the flight before I did. I think you knew the collection route had been exposed. I think you tried to steal a car because every other route belonged to someone else."

"Borrow."

"You intended to return it?"

"No."

"Then steal."

She did not argue again.

Elias continued.

"I also think you have told me only what you needed me to know."

Zoe looked down at the backpack.

The movement confirmed more than words would have.

Elias kept his eyes on the road.

"Mac thinks you are his niece," he said.

"No."

"He told me you were."

"That doesn't mean he thinks it."

The sentence altered the structure of the job.

Elias looked at her in the mirror.

Zoe had already withdrawn behind the backpack.

"What does that mean?"

"No questions."

"Mac sent me into an airport to collect a child under a false relationship. Cain's people followed us and called me by a name I buried. Questions are now part of the journey."

"You agreed."

"I agreed not to interrogate you in Arrivals."

"You moved the border again."

"Yes."

She looked towards the phone.

"Are you calling him?"

"Not while driving."

"That was my rule."

"I agreed."

"What happens when we stop?"

"That depends on what I know before then."

Zoe's fingers moved along the repaired edge of one backpack strap.

At the airport, she had held it as a shield.

At the restaurant, as an anchor.

Now she positioned it on her lap and looked at the zip.

Elias did not look directly.

He watched the road and allowed the decision to happen without observation becoming pressure.

"There's something in the bag," she said.

"I assumed."

"You didn't ask."

"No."

"Why?"

"Because you nearly drove my car down a ramp rather than let me near it."

"That doesn't mean the bag mattered."

"It means you believed it did."

Zoe traced one finger along the zip but did not open it.

"I took something from Cain."

Elias's hands tightened around the wheel.

Only once.

Then released.

"What?"

She looked at him through the mirror.

"No."

"Paper?"

Silence.

“Device?”

Her hand stopped.

Enough.

Elias did not ask the third question.

Zoe noticed.

“You stopped.”

“Yes.”

“Why?”

“Because you gave me the answer you intended to give.”

“That isn’t all of it.”

“I know.”

The road ahead divided around a construction zone.

Elias selected the lane with two exits available rather than one.

A temporary speed limit reduced traffic around them.

Nothing repeated in the mirrors.

Zoe said, “The bag is why they followed me.”

“Probably.”

“You believe me?”

“I believe Cain’s people ignored a public restaurant, offered me a clean exit and risked exposure because recovering you mattered more than remaining invisible. The bag may explain why.”

“That isn’t trust.”

"No."

"What is it?"

"Evidence."

She looked down.

"Trust needs proof."

"Yes."

"Then you haven't proved anything either."

Elias considered that.

"I left your door unlocked."

"You locked it when we left the restaurant."

"You could still open it from inside."

"You came back."

"Yes."

"You didn't tell the server I was lying."

"No."

"You didn't call Mac."

"Not yet."

The final words tightened the air.

Elias heard it.

He corrected the claim rather than defending it.

"I will not call him without telling you first."

Zoe looked up.

"Even if you think it's a safety problem?"

“If it becomes immediate, I act. Otherwise, I tell you.”

The offer was narrow.

Specific.

Testable.

She nodded once.

Not trust.

Acceptance of a term.

They passed beneath an overpass.

The light across the cabin darkened and returned.

Zoe asked, “Where are we going now?”

Elias looked at the navigation screen.

The grandmother’s address remained west, five hours away after the deliberate detour.

The phone had become a compromised object.

The hatchback might already be known.

The road still belonged to Mac’s instruction until Elias chose otherwise.

“For the moment, we keep moving,” he said.

“That isn’t a destination.”

“No.”

“What do you need before choosing?”

“The beginning.”

Zoe understood.

Her hands closed around the backpack.

She could start with the decoy.

That was the shortest explanation for the flight.

It was also the wrong beginning.

The decoy had existed because of everything that came before it.

Cain's house.

The rules.

The showing.

The archive.

The folder.

The hard drive.

Home.

Mac.

Jackie.

Starting with the decoy would turn the story into a failed escape plan.

It would conceal what had made escape necessary.

Zoe looked out at the motorway.

Fields moved past beyond the barrier.

The previous Tuesday, she had known the names of roads near school, which teachers assigned homework on Tuesdays and where Helen kept spare batteries in the kitchen drawer.

Now an ocean sat between that life and the old hatchback.

Elias waited.

He did not prompt her again.

The silence was not empty.

It gave the choice back.

Zoe pulled the backpack closer.

"I'm not showing you what's inside."

"All right."

"I might not tell you everything."

"All right."

"You can't interrupt every time you think something doesn't make sense."

"I can ask."

"You can wait."

"For how long?"

"Until I finish the day."

Elias looked at her in the mirror.

"Day?"

"There were seven."

The number settled into the car.

He reduced speed as traffic thickened ahead.

"All right," he said.

Zoe drew one slow breath.

The first day returned in pieces.

Milk striking pavement.

A school uniform.

A familiar street.

A van where no van belonged.

Helen's voice from the kitchen earlier that morning.

Jackie finishing a sentence Zoe had not needed to complete.

The ordinary life before anyone admitted it had been temporary.

"Day one was Tuesday," she said.